the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP).[6] The BJP wins when it manages to attract enough non-core voters beyond the party faithful. How the BJP attracts these floating non-ideological voters needs to be clearly understood, along with the strategies it adopts to this end. Why do they vote for the BJP? Is it false consciousness, are they deluded or plain stupid—as the liberal imagination would have it? Or is there something we are missing in the party's messaging that voters do not miss? Politics is as much about what the parties stand for as it is about how they convey their messages. We all think we know how the BJP communicates. Now, for the first time, we have the exhaustive data that allows us to draw a comprehensive picture of what the party talks about, how and to whom. And the data paints its own story of why the BJP is rising.

The BJP Speaks More about the Congress Than about Itself

It wasn't until 2019 that the BJP began to talk more about the Congress than it did about itself. That was the first time the party, then in its fifth year in power, started talking more about the principal Opposition party than it talked about itself or its prime minister.

We put all BJP press releases, articles and speeches by party leaders between 2006 and 2019 through the Narad algorithm. When measured this way, we found that, in 2019, the BJP spoke more about the Congress than on any other topic, including Modi, terrorism, defence or Kashmir (see Figure 6.1).

This was extraordinary for several reasons. It broke a historical pattern. There had been election years before, but the BJP had never spoken so much about its rival. Interestingly, even in the 2006–2013 period, when it was out of power, on the Narad Index, the party's emphasis on the ruling Congress was less than half of what it was in 2019. It hovered between 0.291 per 100 words in 2006 and 0.281 in 2013 (see Figure 6.2). After coming to power, however, it started focusing much more on the Congress, going up from 0.391 in 2014 to 0.714 in 2019 on the Index. In other words, mentions of the Congress in the BJP's official communications increased by 82.6 per cent between 2014 and 2019. Normally, Opposition parties speak more about the government in power that they are trying to